Corpus: cuneiform law and treaty → Hebrew (חוקים-ובריתות/)

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Read ../translation-guidelines.md first, then this file, then the shared renderings.md, then the project's own project.md.

Goal

Translate the cuneiform treaties and law collections that matter most for the **legal and covenantal Torah**: Deuteronomy 12–30 (the treaty frame, Deut 13, the curses of Deut 28, the oath of Deut 29), the Covenant Code (Exod 21–23), Leviticus 26, and the laws of Deut 19–25.
The corpus comes from items 3, 4 and 6 of ../curated-translation-candidates.md and the relevance survey (../curation-surveys/relevance-survey--2026-10-16.md, items 42–43 and the law collections).
The Deuteronomy units of the commentary (../../../דברים-5/פירוש/) contain, as of 2026-10-17, the verse text and the unit titles but no commentary yet: these translations are meant to shape that commentary from the start, as the flood corpus did for Gen 6–9. Their parallels indexes therefore key to **exact verses and words**.

The user's standing decisions (from the flood and creation corpora) apply:

- partial niqqud (guidelines §6.2): names at first occurrence and ambiguous words;
- deities are never assimilated to biblical names; biblical place names are used for places the Bible names (Babylon = בָּבֶל, Nineveh = נִינְוֵה, Ḥarrān = חָרָן, Kalḫu = כֶּלַח).

The texts and how they relate

#	Project folder	Text	Language, date	Relation to the Torah
1	`1--אמנת-הירושה-של-אסרחדון/`	**Esarhaddon's Succession Treaty** (SAA 2 6, "Vassal Treaties of Esarhaddon", 691 composite lines), with the **Tell Tayinat copy** (SAA 2 15, 443 lines)	Akkadian (Neo-Assyrian; the curse list partly Standard Babylonian), 672 BCE	Deut 13 (the duty to report the prophet, the ecstatic, the brother, the son, the daughter; to seize and kill the inciter); Deut 13:1 and 4:2 (do not alter the words); Deut 6:5 (love "as yourselves"); Deut 28:20–44 (the curse sequence Sîn → Šamaš → Ninurta → Venus ↔ 28:27–30; bronze sky and iron earth ↔ 28:23; cannibalism ↔ 28:53–57); Deut 29:9–14 (the oath of the absent generations); Deut 31:9–13, 24–26 (the written tablet kept and read); Lev 26:19, 29.
2	`2--חוקי-חמורבי/`	**The Laws of Hammurabi**: prologue, laws §1–§282 (the gap §66–§99 not in the base text), epilogue – 3,641 composite lines	Akkadian (OB), c. 1750 BCE	The Covenant Code (Exod 21–23) and Deut 19–25; the prologue and epilogue (justice, the stele, blessings and curses) ↔ the covenant frame. Base: CDLI P464358 (composite with normalization and English), checked against the Louvre stele and SEAL 7520 (`../curated-translation-candidates.md`, item 4).
3	`3--חוקי-אשנונה/`	**The Laws of Eshnunna** (CDLI P480696, 195 lines; exemplars A IM 51059, B IM 52614, C)	Akkadian (OB), 19th c. BCE	§53 ↔ Exod 21:35 (the closest verbal parallel); §54–57 the gorer and the dog ↔ 21:28–32, 36; §12–13, §60 ↔ 22:1–2; §42–48 ↔ 21:18–27; §25–31 ↔ Deut 22:22–29; §36–37 ↔ Exod 22:6–10.

#	Project folder	Text	Language, date	Relation to the Torah
4	4--החוקים-האשוריים-התיכונים-A/	**The Middle Assyrian Laws, Tablet A** (ORACC tcma P281779, KAV 1, 828 lines, §1–§59)	Akkadian (MA), tablet 11th c., laws 14th c.	Deut 22:13–29 (§12–19, §55–56), 25:3 (§18–19), 25:5–12 (§8, §30, §33, §43), 24:1–4 (§36, §45); Exod 21:22–25 (§50–53), 22:15–17 (§47, §55–56); Gen 24:65, 38 (§40–41); Num 5 (§2, §17).
5	5--חוקי-ליפית-אישתר/	**The Laws of Lipit-Ištar** (CDLI P464355, 503 lines, Sumerian)	Sumerian, Isin, c. 1930 BCE	Prologue ↔ Lev 25:10 (דרור); §–12 16 ↔ Deut 23:16–17; §17 ↔ Deut 19:16–19; §25–27 ↔ Gen 21:10, Judg 11; §29 ↔ Judg 14:20; §33 ↔ Deut 22:13–19; §34–37 ↔ Exod 22:13–14; epilogue ↔ Deut 27–28.
6	6--חוקי-אור-נמה/	**The Laws of Ur-Namma** (CDLI P432130, 628 lines, Sumerian, with Civil's additional laws)	Sumerian, Ur III, 21st c. BCE	Prologue ↔ Exod 22:20–22, Lev 19:35–36, Ezek 45:9–12; laws ↔ Exod 21:12–27, 22:6–14; Deut 22:23–27; Num 27:8 (b008–b011).
7	7--החוקים-האשוריים-התיכונים-B/	**The Middle Assyrian Laws, Tablet B** (ORACC P281780, KAV 2, 245 lines, §1–§20)	Akkadian (MA)	§8–9, §20 ↔ Deut 19:14, 27:17 (boundaries); §1 ↔ Deut 21:17; §6 ↔ Ruth 4, Jer 32.

Reading order for the commentary: project 2 first for the Covenant Code (Exod 21–23: §250–252, §196–214, §117–126, §244–267; then Lev 18–20, 24, 25, Num 5, Deut 19–25 and the epilogue for Deut 27–28, Lev 26); project 1 first for Deuteronomy (§10, §12, §18, §29 for Deut 13; §4, §57 and §35–36 for 13:1 and 4:2; §24 for 6:5; §25, §34 for 29:13–14; §35 for 31:9–13; §37–§56 and §63–§65 for 28:20–44 and 28:23; §47, §69, §75 for 28:53–57). Then the other collections (projects 3–7) for the same verses: LE §53–58 and §12–13 beside LH §250–252 (Exod 21–22); MAL A §12–19, §55–56 for Deut 22; §8, §30–33, §43 for Deut 25; §40–41 for Gen 38; the Sumerian prologues for Exod 22:20–22 and Lev 25:10.

Shared conventions for this corpus

- **`renderings.md` in this folder is shared by all projects of the corpus.** It inherits the flood corpus's and the creation corpus's shared renderings (`../סיפורי-המבול/renderings.md`, `../סיפורי-הבריאה-המסופוטמיים/renderings.md`) as its default: divine names, formulas and key terms are the same in all three corpora. It adds the legal and treaty terms (oath, curse, "if", the apodosis formulas) and records where it deviates from the earlier corpora, with the reason.
- **The legal "if".** Law collections (*šumma awīlum* …, "if a man …") and treaty stipulations (*šumma attunu* …, "if you …") both begin with *šumma* = אִם. In the treaties the *šumma* clause is an **oath**: "if you do X (may the gods punish you)" = "you shall not do X"; "if you do not do X" = "you shall do X". The Hebrew keeps the oath form (אִם … לֹא תִּנָּצְרוּ), which is also the native Hebrew oath syntax (אִם = "I swear not", אִם לֹא = "I swear that"): see `renderings.md` §3.
- **Repeated formulas get identical Hebrew**, verified by script. Esarhaddon's treaty repeats the crown-prince formula about 60 times, the "if you …" clauses and the curse formulas hundreds of times.
- A project translator does not edit the shared file during drafting; proposals go into the project's `project.md`, and the corpus coordinator merges them.
- **Parallels index:** each project keeps its index (guidelines §7.3); `parallels-index.md` here merges them into one table ordered by Bible verse.
- **Law terms:** `renderings.md` §5 (fixed for LH, binding for project 3): *šumma* = אִם always, *awīlum* = (בֶּן אִישׁ) אִישׁ, *muškēnum* = מִסְכֵּן, *iddâk* = יֻהָרַג, *maḫar ilim* = לִפְנֵי הָאֵל, *dīnum* = דִּין, *kīma* = כְּ (never תַּחַת), *nakāpu* = נָגַף.
- **Recension tags** (guidelines §6.8): in project 1 a line, or words, translated from the Tell Tayinat copy because the composite (Nimrud) tablets are broken there are tagged {תיינת} / {תיינת: …}.

The open decisions, settled (2026-10-18)

The user delegated the open decisions of projects 1–7 to the coordinator ("use your judgment"). The translators' choices are **confirmed** and are binding from now on; each project's `project.md` keeps the alternatives and reasons:

- *adê* = אֲמָנָה (not בְּרִית, not the debated cognate עֵדוּת, which is kept in the notes as a parallel).
- Kings named in the Bible keep the biblical form (אֵסַר־חַדּוֹן, סַנְחֵרִיב); the others are transcribed from the Akkadian (guidelines §6.4 rule 6).
- *raggimu* = נָבִיא, *maḫḫû* = מְשֻׁגָּע (both with first-occurrence notes).
- Tayinat's additions to lines intact at Nimrud stay in the apparatus.
- *awīlum* = בֶּן אִישׁ / אִישׁ, *muškēnum* = מִסְכֵּן (the Hebrew word borrowed from it; the modern sense "pitiable" is explained at the first occurrence): the class tiers must stay visible.

- Hammurabi = חַמּוּרַבִּי (the form Hebrew readers know; חַמּוּרָפִי is given in the introduction).
- LH §66–§99 (the erased stele columns) are **deferred**: they need Roth 1997 or Driver & Miles, which are not in hand (sources/_records-only--Hammurabi-gap-laws-and-Hebrew/).
- The smaller choices of each project (e.g. עדות שקרים, LH §21, רעולה, בדיל, בא על, נִקֵּב, יתלוהו?, ארד, בן חורין, תחום, חֵלֶף, פילגש) stand as drafted.
- **2026-10-21 (cross-corpus harmonization, decided by the lead):** Inana = אִינַנָּה, always vocalized (LI 51; was אִינַאנָּה); *sukkallu* = וזיר (MAL B o iii 30; was שר); *ṣabātu* stays תָּפַס in this corpus (renderings.md, end of §6).

Status

#	Project	Status
1	Esarhaddon's Succession Treaty + Tell Tayinat	**complete (first draft)**, 2026-10-17: 691 composite entries + 15 Tayinat-only entries (703 Hebrew lines in all, with the A-lines), seven parts (§1–9, 10–21, 22–29, 30–36, 37–56, 57–89, 90–107) by sequential sub-agents, three review passes each, harmonized by the coordinator, verified by `verify.py` (0 problems); `translation.rtl.md` generated (`build_translation.py`, 56 footnotes); 771 parallels rows merged into `parallels-index.md`; print stub `../1-הדפסה/חוקים-ובריתות/אמנת-הירושה-של-אסרחדון.rtl.md`. Open decisions: `1-אמנת-הירושה-של-אסרחדון/project.md`.
2	Laws of Hammurabi	**complete (first draft)**, 2026-10-17: all 3,641 composite lines (CDLI P464358, checked against the Louvre stele P249253 and SEAL 7520): prologue 1–303, §1–§65, end of §100, §101–§282, epilogue 3144′–3641′; the gap laws §66–§99 not translated (no open base text: open decision). Twelve annotated files by twelve sequential sub-agents in priority order, three review passes each, coordinator harmonization, `verify.py --strict` 0 problems; `translation.rtl.md` (topic and § headings, 130 footnotes); 1,263 parallels rows merged; print stub `../2-הדפסה/חוקים-ובריתות/2-חוקי-חמורבי.rtl.md`. Open decisions: `2-חוקי-חמורבי/project.md`.
3	Laws of Eshnunna (`3-חוקי-אשנונה/`)	**complete (first draft)**, 2026-10-18: all 195 composite lines (CDLI P480696; date formula 1–7, §1–§60 with §9a, §18a, §47a), checked against exemplars A (IM 51059), B (IM 52614), C; one sequential sub-agent (T1), three review passes, `../laws_verify.py LE` 0 problems; `translation.rtl.md` (22 footnotes); 100 parallels rows; print stub. Open decisions: `3-חוקי-אשנונה/project.md`.
4	Middle Assyrian Laws A (`4-החוקים-האשוריים-התיכונים-A/`)	**complete (first draft)**, 2026-10-18: all 828 tablet lines (ORACC tcma P281779, de Ridder 2021; §1–§59 and the colophon) in three annotated files by three sequential sub-agents (T2–T4), three review passes each, `../laws_verify.py MAL --strict` 0 problems; `translation.rtl.md` (25 footnotes); 262 parallels rows; print stub. Open decisions: `4-.../project.md`.

#	Project	Status
5	Laws of Lipit-Ištar (`5--חוקי-ליפית-אישתר/`)	**complete (first draft)**, 2026-10-18: all 503 lines of CDLI P464355 (prologue 1–107′, §4–§38 108′–429′, epilogue and colophon 430′–503′), Sumerian, checked against 13 exemplars; two sequential sub-agents (T5 laws, T6 frame), `../laws_verify.py LI --strict` 0 problems; `translation.rtl.md` (17 footnotes); parallels merged; print stub. Open decisions: `5-.../project.md`.
6	Laws of Ur-Namma (`6--חוקי-אור-נמה/`)	**complete (first draft)**, 2026-10-18: all 628 labelled lines of CDLI P432130 (prologue 1–181, laws 181.a–474 and Civil's b001–f008, epilogue g009–g028′), Sumerian; § concordance with Roth 1997 by content (Part T7; uncertain numbers marked); two sequential sub-agents (T7 laws, T8 frame), `../laws_verify.py UN --strict` 0 problems; `translation.rtl.md` (22 footnotes); parallels merged; print stub. Open decisions: `6-.../project.md`.
7	Middle Assyrian Laws B (`7-החוקים-האשוריים-התיכונים-B/`)	**complete (first draft)**, 2026-10-18 (optional addition): all 245 lines (ORACC P281780, §1–§20), one sub-agent (T9), `../laws_verify.py MALB --strict` 0 problems; `translation.rtl.md`; 59 parallels rows; print stub.

Corpus-level files

File	What
`renderings.md`	Shared renderings, binding for all projects.
`translator-brief--laws.md`	The common brief of the sequential translators of projects 3–7 (reading list, tools, format, echo control, process, Part section). Reusable for MAL C–O, the Middle Assyrian Palace Decrees, the Edict of Ammiṣaduqa.
`laws_config.py`, `laws_*.py`	Shared scripts of projects 3–7 (guidelines §10).
`parallels-index.md`	The projects' parallels indexes merged, ordered by Bible verse (Exodus and Deuteronomy by chapter), with "Key findings for the commentary" (EST, LH, and the other collections) at the top. Regenerate with `python3 -I build_parallels_index.py` (this folder; it reads every project; the older `1-.../build_parallels_index.py` knows only project 1 – do not use it).